

Ship It: Cruel Optimism as an Interface

Supporting Essay for the Interactive Artefact

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Introduction and Thesis

My artefact *Ship It* is a browser-based interactive experience built as the internal HR dashboard of a fictional AAA studio, "Lumen Interactive". The user plays a Senior Producer in the six weeks before a flagship release and makes seven decisions. Each one looks like a routine management task, but together they enact what Cote and Harris (2021) call the "cruel optimism of good crunch". The artefact responds directly to their thesis: the industry sustains exploitative labour practices not through open coercion but through a positive, friendly discourse — the language of passion, family, and the "dream job".

The central provocation is a shift of perspective. Most representations of crunch place the viewer in the position of the victim — the burnt-out developer. *Ship It* instead puts the user on the management side and shows that none of the available choices are "right" — a direct visual translation of Cote and Harris's argument that the problem is structural rather than individual.

Author Positionality

I have worked as a frontend developer for eleven years and have been through several pre-release crunch cycles in adjacent tech sectors. I recognise the patterns Cote and Harris (2021) describe as someone who has worked evenings and weekends, received "motivational" Slack messages during crunch, taken extended sick leave after a release, and watched colleagues be laid off shortly after shipping. My experience is not from games specifically, but the structural mechanisms the source describes — the discourse of passion, "voluntary" overtime, and metrics divorced from human cost — extend across the broader creative-tech labour landscape, as Bulut (2020) and Gregg (2011) document. This shapes my methodological position: the artefact draws on embodied memory of crunch and adopts the management perspective because that is the side I observed as the recipient of its decisions.

Theoretical Framework

Cote and Harris (2021) analyse the discursive construction of crunch through Lauren Berlant's (2011) concept of cruel optimism — an attachment to an object that actively prevents one's flourishing. In games, that object is the "dream job": the rhetoric of passion and the elite identity of the "game developer" keeps workers in conditions that damage their health, relationships, and eventually their love of the craft. The authors show how the language of "good crunch" — voluntary, team-driven, supplied with pizza — is separated from "bad crunch" and thereby legitimises the system as a whole. In opposing "bad" crunch, the industry protects crunch as a principle.

The argument is supported by adjacent literature. Bulut (2020) introduces the concept of a "ludopolitical regime" — soft power relations in which the playful character of the work conceals its exploitative nature. IGDA surveys show that most developers continue to crunch. The 2004 "ea_spouse" campaign, the scandals at Rockstar and CD Projekt Red, and the mass layoffs of 2023–2025 — over thirty thousand jobs cut while the industry reported record profits — confirm the structural nature of the problem.

Design Justification: Form as Argument

The choice of the producer perspective enacts Cote and Harris's central structural argument: crunch is built into the system rather than produced by the cruelty of individual managers. By placing the user in a managerial role, I remove their moral distance. None of the seven choices has a clean ethical answer.

The cheerful corporate aesthetic — light theme, soft colours, smiling avatars, upbeat copy — is a literal visualisation of the discourse Cote and Harris analyse. A button labelled "Align on flexibility" instead of "Cancel his paternity leave" is "good crunch" in action.

The user physically clicks through the language of cruel optimism. Decision 5, in which Priya is denied a raise and offered a post-ship "review", is drawn from my own experience: a developer who carried a release was given a "spot bonus" instead of a base salary adjustment, framed in language that matched almost exactly what Cote and Harris identify as a tool for deferring fair compensation under the cover of care.

The hidden metrics and private team diary entries materialise what Berlant calls the "affective infrastructure" — the invisible emotional labour that never appears in corporate reporting. The user sees a cheerful green "energy" bar; the unredacted ending reveals it as "Marcus: 'She said I could split it. I don't think I can say no.'" This gap between the upper and lower layers of the interface is the central aesthetic strategy of the artefact.

The three final screens follow the rhetorical structure of the source. The "Performance

Review" shows how the industry narrates itself, and every element of it performs the discourse Cote and Harris analyse. The headline "You shipped on time" and the "Exceeds Expectations" badge frame the outcome as unambiguous success. The CEO quote invokes the exact vocabulary the source identifies as core to cruel optimism — "passion", "commitment", "world-class" — folding the team's exhaustion into a story of shared identity. Most telling are the metrics: Team Morale at 28% and Build Quality at 55% appear in the same neutral visual language as Schedule and Budget, as if they were equally legitimate KPIs rather than evidence of harm. The closing line — "Team retention metrics will be reviewed in Q3" — is the source's argument made literal: human cost is real but procedurally deferred, never aggregated against the success it produced. The "Unredacted Report" then breaks this frame, revealing the real outcomes. The final screen — "There is no ending where everyone is okay" — restates Cote and Harris's structural conclusion: the problem is not the individual choices, but the architecture that makes every choice exploitative.

Critical Position

The artefact takes a deliberately sharp position. I do not offer a "balanced view" of crunch, because the academic literature of the past decade does not support that balance. Bulut, Cote and Harris, Peticca-Harris and colleagues, and successive IGDA reports converge: crunch structurally exploits workers, disproportionately pushes out women, disabled people, and those with caring responsibilities, and damages the games themselves. It is worth acknowledging that studios such as Supergiant Games and Media Molecule have publicly adopted sustainable development schedules and still shipped critically acclaimed titles, demonstrating that alternatives exist. However, as Cote and Harris (2021) argue, these counter-examples do not refute the structural thesis — they remain exceptional precisely because the industry's dominant incentive structures continue to reward crunch. An artefact that framed crunch as "morally grey" would reproduce exactly the "good crunch" discourse the source argues against.

Limitations

The artefact works with a single studio and does not cover the global QA outsourcing chains that Bulut identifies as the most precarious segment of the industry. The five-minute runtime also excludes slower forms of emotional exhaustion that only appear over years.

Conclusion

Ship It is not meant to entertain or to teach "better management". Its purpose is to make Cote and Harris's argument physically felt through an interface. When the user clicks a cheerful green button and watches it destroy someone, they experience in miniature the structure of

cruel optimism that keeps the industry in its current state. The artefact argues that the language of passion and dreams is not a neutral motivational tool — it is an infrastructure of exploitation, and no individual "good" choices exist inside it until that infrastructure is dismantled.

Interactive artefact: <https://interactive-artifact-psi.vercel.app>

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